Chapter 1

Chapter 1.1 Hear No Salvation

The Kafka family stood out as unusual among the wealthiest households in the UK. This family name is from Czechia, where it was quite prevalent. No one expected someone of Czech descent to make it this far.

Before even arriving at their residence, Ben had already looked into the family's background. He wanted to know the lineage of the family he was about to work for, particularly that of Edward Kafka, the man he had been assigned to assist.

Ben wasn't sure if anyone else knew Edward's real name. Even though Edward had slightly changed his name to make it sound more British, it still retained a strong resemblance to his birth name, *Eduard Vojtěch Kafka.*

Edward's journey in politics commenced without much fanfare. He was merely another member of the National Liberal Party—or simply the Liberals—but people usually ignored him at party gatherings. However, this changed when he ascended to the role of Deputy Leader. His name began to feature more frequently in newspapers, attracting the attention of MPs regarding his opinions.

As the Liberals were gaining increased popularity, Edward was emerging as one of the leading members of the party. If he were to eventually take the position of party leader and the Liberals secured victory in the upcoming general election, then there would be minimal obstacles between him and Downing Street.

Ben was just fifteen years old at that moment. He never expected Edward to put someone so young with the responsibilities of looking after the Kafka family, especially with Edward's political career taking off. The family seemed to have one foot in both politics and business, with both worlds leading to the same entrance.

However, Ben's job wasn't all that difficult. His main duty was simply to look after Edward's only son, Theodore.

Theodore was a quiet and rather shy boy. He rarely spoke unless spoken to, but he was an intelligent child who paid close attention to everything around him. Whenever Ben was with him, he noticed how obedient Theodore was, almost to the point of being afraid to make even the slightest mistake.

Ben was there to keep an eye on the boy, make sure he was safe, and report his activities to Edward. Yet, as time went on, he began to notice more than just the things he was supposed to report. He could see the pressure Theodore carried, even at such a young age, and sometimes found himself feeling sorry for him.

On one occasion, Ben gave Theodore a piece of candy. The boy happily ate it, but shortly afterwards, he seemed to remember something his father had told him about keeping his teeth clean. Ben watched as Theodore hurried off to the bathroom and brushed his teeth three times in a row. It was a small incident, but one that stayed with Ben.

Sometimes, Ben saw how Edward treated his son when no one else was around. He had seen Edward hit Theodore, yet Theodore always spoke fondly of his father whenever they talked.

Edward's bond with his wife—Matilda—was not as romantic as it appeared in the newspapers and on television. They rarely seemed to argue, but they also didn't seem close. To Ben, their marriage felt more like a business arrangement that brought the Kafka and Howard families together while giving the impression of a happy family.

However, within its walls, it resembled a building that hadn't discovered how to be a home.

Chapter 1.2 What Lies Beneath

Ben would never forget that night, when the jackdaws seemed to fill the darkness.

He awoke precisely at two in the morning to the noise of gunfire. Ben, who had learned a significant amount about guns and military from his deceased grandfather, recognized it instantly without needing to reflect on it.

Ben sprang out of bed and grabbed his gun, even though he's not sure he can use it. He's weak, mentally and physically, but he knew he couldn't just stand there and do nothing.

He had no idea about who might have been shot. If it was Edward or Theodore, then it was all over.

But leaving Theodore alone was not an option, so Ben tried to find him. He has the responsibility to protect the boy, even if he needs to sacrifice his own life.

He slowly opened Theodore's bedroom door. The room was dark, with only a faint moonlight coming through the windows. Ben could barely see Theodore standing by the spacious window that looked out the back garden.

Theodore was peeking through the curtains, watching something below. Noticing that Theodore was safe, Ben exhaled softly in relief and approached him.

"Theo... Theo.... "

Yet, Theodore didn't respond.

He stood completely still, as if he had been frozen in place. His face was pale, and only then did Ben notice that the boy was trembling.

Theodore finally looked at him. He bites his inner lips. "Ben... I think... uh— my dad ... accidentally killed someone."

Ben stared at him in shock. He blinked a few times before turning towards the back garden.

He knows Edward loved having the house well lit. There were lamps everywhere, each with a different style, placed in almost every corner of the house. There was hardly a dark spot anywhere. But tonight, the back garden had nothing but moonlight.

Ben squinted. There was a sealed coffin in the back garden, while a few of the household staff were digging a patch of soil nearby.

His thoughts quickly sought a more logical reason for what he observed. Anything made more sense than what Theodore had just suggested. As far as Ben knew, Edward Kafka might have been many things. But surely he couldn't be cruel enough to kill someone.

Or maybe Ben was just too naive for a reality like this.

Ben lowered his gaze slightly, only to accidentally meet Edward's eyes. Edward was gazing up at him from the back garden. There was something cold in his stare, as if Ben had stumbled upon a secret Edward was never meant to discover.

From his position, Ben could see the blood staining Edward's hands. However, even more startling was what he noticed next.

Edward was holding a baby.

Whose baby was that? Ben quickly ran through the names of every woman who had been coming and going from the Kafka family. He knows it wasn't Matilda's. It was impossible that she had given birth without anyone being aware of it.

Whatever the truth was, Ben averted his gaze quickly, he realized the gravity of the situation. Maybe, his career might be over. Perhaps his life would be too.

Chapter 1.3 The Mouth of Hell

Ben was given the responsibility of taking care of the Kafka family in Prague after what happened that night. While there, he was assigned to look after Edward's father, *Šimon Vojtěch Kafka*.

His five years in Prague were a nightmare. Ben struggled significantly with learning Czech and trying to adapt to the environment around him. Additionally, Šimon's difficult demeanor didn't make things any easier.

At last, that nightmare had come to an end. Ben was now back in London working for Edward again. He would not mind at all if his contract was terminated. Five years of working for the Kafka family and forcing himself to keep his mouth shut are enough for him.

After waiting for some time in Edward's office, the owner of the room finally arrived.

Edward stepped inside, loosening his tie as he walked in. He stopped when he noticed Ben, raised his eyebrows slightly, then smiled.

"It's been a long time, Ben."

Ben blinked a few times, his brows lifting in surprise. His eyes moved from one corner of the room to another, then back to Edward. He even glanced over his shoulder, as if checking whether he had somehow entered the wrong room.

For a brief moment, he thought he had.

Where had Edward's personality from five years ago gone? Those cold eyes that never let just anyone get close.

Ben forced a smile as they shook hands, even giving a slight bow. Whatever it took, Ben was determined to look as polite as possible in front of Edward.

"I-I'm doing well, absolutely well. Oh! Congratulations on your new position as leader of the Liberals, Sir. I heard you received quite a lot of praise after taking over."

After the Liberals leader resigned, Edward secured the leadership position within the party. This marked the beginning of Edward's next significant duty, which involved maintaining a positive public image leading up to the forthcoming general election.

Ben began connecting the dots in his head. This new personality was a part of Edward's strategy to enhance his reputation.

Edward released his hand and gestured for Ben to sit back down. His polite and friendly manner somehow made him even more frightening. Ben simply followed. Ben wasn't about to risk dying just because he refused to sit down.

"It's nothing. The position isn't something to talk about. I'm struggling and overworked now. It's hard to sleep these days, Ben."

Ben's eyebrows twitched for a fraction of a second before he nodded and gave a small laugh. But inside, one thought kept circling his head.

Edward was actually opening up to him?

It was the first time Ben had heard Edward discuss his personal struggles with him, as though he let Ben glimpse behind the wall he usually kept between himself and everyone else. What importance could Ben possibly have? He had never considered himself particularly important to the family.

Edward moved closer. Ben flinched slightly, but quickly straightened himself when Edward merely sat down in the chair beside him. For a moment, Ben couldn't help but wonder why Edward had come so close.

Edward nudged his cup of tea towards Ben with a smile. "You look a bit pale. Are you alright? That journey from Prague to London must have been exhausting. I apologize. I'll book a flight for you next time—"

"Ahhh—no! No, that's fine, Sir! The journey was perfectly fine, and I'm doing just fine. Thank you for your concern." Ben quickly cut Edward off. Then, after thinking about it, he realised he probably shouldn't have interrupted him.

Edward leaned back in his chair, his eyes never leaving Ben. "Alright, then. Since you're alright with it, do you want to return there? Seems like you're enjoying looking after my dad."

Ben fell silent at the question. "I do—but … why did you bring me back here if you plan to send me there again?"

Edward turned his attention to a nearby desk drawer. He opened it and took out several documents. These documents highlighted Ben's educational accomplishments.

“I heard you were quite good academically.” That was all Edward said. Ben couldn’t tell whether it was a compliment or a question he was supposed to answer.

When Edward remained silent, Ben opted to respond regardless. "Yes. Wasn’t that the reason for my recruitment? I wasn't particularly physically capable and had minimal work experience back then.”

Before Ben could continue, Edward cut him off.

“Theodore’s grades have been getting worse lately, and *my little boy* has very good grades. Still, I am struggling to find a tutor for him.”

His little boy? Oh ... *that boy.*

The boy’s name had been in the papers long before his face ever was, *Gathur Delano Kafka*. He had been added to the Kafka family as Edward and Matilda’s second child.

Strangely enough, the people who had been in the garden that night and witnessed what happened had disappeared as well. Now, it was as if everyone had simply accepted that Matilda had carried Edward’s second child, even though Ben knew perfectly well that boy had not been hers.

Ben assumed there had to be plenty of other household staff in the house who knew about it. Yet they had all chosen to turn a blind eye and keep their mouths shut, as though that night had never happened.

“Do you want me to tutor Theodore?” Ben tried to wrap things up.

Theodore's grades would eventually become a problem for Edward's public image. Perhaps Theodore had lost focus on his studies, that makes sense if Edward is trying his best to find a tutor.

"No. For my son."

Ben raised both eyebrows. "Y-yes. Your son, Theodore."

Edward leaned towards him before lowering his voice to a whisper. "Ben, I'm not talking about Theo. *I'm talking about my little Kafka*."

Ben went completely still. His brows furrowed as he stared at Edward, confused by the way he had spoken about Theodore as though he weren't his son.

Then another thought crossed his mind. "I thought you said he had good grades. Did I misunderstand something?"

Edward let out a quiet laugh and shook his head. "No, Ben. You didn't misunderstand anything. You are so smart, I'm so proud of you."

Ben stared at him in confusion, his brows slightly furrowed as he tried to figure out what Edward was thinking.

Edward leaned back in his chair. "As a tutor, assistant, guard, whatever it is. I want you to keep an eye on him for the rest of your life." A wide grin spread across his face.

"Because he's my son. *My son.*"